

The well-known quote by American motivational speaker and entrepreneur Jim Rohn is: 'You are the average of the five people you spend the most time with.' In other words, the more time you spend with people, the more like them you will become. This is particularly important when it comes to mindsets and financial environments and habits (which we'll look at more closely in Part Three). As you consider your Money Environment, consider the following question about the five people you spend the most time with: How are they influencing your money mindset, environment, behaviour and habits?

But let's extrapolate this concept further and take it to its extreme. Does this mean that if we surround ourselves with financially successful people we will, by that very fact alone, also become financially successful?

Is setting up a positive financial environment really that simple?

Now, I'm certainly not arguing that's the sole recipe to financial success. However, there is some evidence to support you at least in leaning that way. In 2013 a study was conducted by Catherine Shea, Erin Davisson and Gráinne Fitzsimons called 'Riding Other People's Coattails: Individuals with low self-control value self-control in other people'. The study looked at whether people with low self-control can improve their self-control by surrounding themselves with strong-willed friends. In this study, researchers found consistent support for what they believe 'reflects a social self-regulatory process, in which those with low self-control can attempt to compensate for their shortcomings by drawing closer to high self-control others'. In other words, if you have an area in your life you think might be a weakness, you might recruit a friend for whom that area is a strength. They may help you through modelling positive habits and behaviour or through accountability.

The researchers themselves acknowledged in their report that they 'do not mean to imply that relying on others will completely outweigh the drawbacks of low self-control'. After all, your friend with high self-control isn't going to follow you around and smack the credit card out of your hand every time you go to buy something. Rather, their findings 'suggest that individuals with low self-control may play an active role in attempting to overcome their individual weaknesses' by strategically seeking social partners who model great behaviour and hold them accountable. Those social partners may be friends in your peer group or people you follow on